

Claim Intake and Triage Guide

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Audience: Claims intake staff and adjusters

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This guide expands on the intake stage referenced at the start of the Claims Handling Procedures Manual with the specific triage decisions made before a claim reaches full adjudication.

1. Purpose of Triage

Not every claim requires the same handling path. Triage sorts a newly reported claim by complexity and urgency so it reaches the right resource quickly — a straightforward glass claim does not need the same handling depth as a claim with a fatality, and routing both identically wastes capacity that urgent claims need.

2. Information Collected at Intake

At minimum, intake collects: the policyholder's identity and policy number, the date, time, and location of loss, a description of what happened, the vehicles and parties involved, and whether injuries are reported. This baseline information is what triage classification (Section 3) is based on — triage does not wait for a full investigation to begin routing the claim.

3. Triage Categories

A claim is classified at intake into one of several handling tracks: **standard** (routine physical damage, no injury, no coverage ambiguity apparent), **injury** (any reported injury, routed with priority given potential Medical Payments or Part B involvement), **total-loss-likely** (severity described suggests the vehicle may not be repairable, routed toward early total-loss vendor engagement), **catastrophe** (matches a declared CAT event, routed per the Catastrophe Claims Surge Protocol), and **complex** (coverage ambiguity, multiple parties, or any fact pattern matching a Fraud Indicators Guide trigger apparent even at intake).

4. Reclassification

A claim's triage category set at intake is a starting point, not a permanent label — a claim initially triaged as standard is reclassified to complex or total-loss-likely as soon as new information (an estimate coming in far above expectations, a fact pattern matching a fraud indicator) makes the original classification inaccurate. Reclassification does not restart the claim number or file, only the handling path.

5. Assignment by Category

Standard claims are assigned by adjuster capacity; injury and complex claims are assigned preferentially to adjusters with the relevant experience level; catastrophe-classified claims are assigned per the surge staffing plan in the Catastrophe Claims Surge Protocol rather than the standard capacity-based assignment.

6. Same-Day Actions

Regardless of triage category, every newly reported claim receives the acknowledgment described in the Claims Customer Communication Standards, Section 2, within one business day, and — where a covered auto is disabled — an inquiry about roadside assistance or rental reimbursement needs (Rental Reimbursement and Loss of Use Claims Guide) is made proactively rather than waiting for the policyholder to ask.

7. Triage Is Not a Coverage Determination

Triage classification and any same-day actions taken (acknowledgment, roadside dispatch) do not constitute or imply a coverage determination — the five-step adjudication sequence in the Claims Adjudication Guidelines still governs the actual coverage outcome, and intake staff performing triage are not authorized to state a coverage position to the policyholder.

8. Documentation Standard

The intake record documents the triage category assigned, the specific facts that drove the classification (Section 3), and any reclassification with its trigger (Section 4), so the claim file shows a complete record of how the claim was routed from first report through to adjudication.